

CURRICULUM VITAE

Alissa Rivero

alissa.rivero@duke.edu | <https://alissarivero.github.io/>

EDUCATION

2026-Present	<i>Incoming Ph.D. in developmental psychology</i>	Duke University
	Advisors: Dorsa Amir and Tamar Kushnir	
2021-2025	<i>B.A. in psychology, with distinction</i>	Duke University
	Advisor: Michael Tomasello	

FELLOWSHIPS

2026-2031	<i>National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship</i>	\$159,000
2026-2031	<i>Dean's Graduate Fellowship</i> , Duke University	\$268,100

PUBLICATIONS

Click ➡ to access the manuscripts.

Rivero, A. & Amir, D. (*in press*) The developmental origins of egalitarianism. Response to Stibbard-Hawkes and von Rueden's "Egalitarianism is not Equality: Moving from outcome to process in the study of human political organization". *Behavioral and Brain Sciences* ➡

Rivero, A., Vasil, J., & Tomasello, M. (*invited revision*) 2- and 3-year-olds coordinate decisions in dyads and triads. *Child Development*.

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

Rivero, A., Brouwers, J., Vieth, A., & Hard, B. M. (*in prep*) Improving undergraduate student experiences with group work.

STUDIES IN PROGRESS

Rivero, A. & Tomasello, M. (*in progress*). Children's effort after instructions go away.

Rivero, A. & Tomasello, M. (*in progress*). Children's learning from peer versus adult instruction.

Rivero, A. & Amir, D. (*in progress*). Resetting: Children's generative heuristic.

Rivero, A., Pitt, B., & Amir, D. (*in progress*). Children exploit when the goal is motivating.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Rivero, A., Vasil, J., Tomasello, M. (2026, April). *Three's a crowd: 2- and 3-year-olds coordinate decisions in dyads and triads*. Flash talk presented at the 2026 Cognitive Development Society (CDS) preconference on strategic decision-making, Montreal, CA.

Rivero, A. & Tomasello, M. (2026, April). *Instruction on children's exploration and effort*. Poster presented at the 2026 Cognitive Development Society (CDS), Montreal, CA.

Rivero, A., Vasil, J., Tomasello, M. (2026, April). *Three's a crowd: 2- and 3-year-olds coordinate decisions in dyads and triads*. Poster presented at the 2026 Cognitive Development Society (CDS), Montreal, CA.

Rivero, A. & Amir, D. (2026, March). *A time for starting over and a time for iterating: Variability in creative generation across development*. Poster presented at the 2026 North Carolina Cognition Conference, Durham, NC.

Rivero, A., Vasil, J., Tomasello, M. (2026, March). *Three's a crowd: 2- and 3-year-olds coordinate decisions in dyads and triads*. Poster presented at the 2026 North Carolina Cognition Conference, Durham, NC.

Rivero, A., Brouwers, J., Dannis, T., Wynn, S. (2026, February). *Group work: Sometimes it works, and sometimes it doesn't*. Presentation for the 2026 Annual Critical Questions in Education Conference, San Diego, CA.

Rivero, A. (2025, June). *Bringing psychology to life: Changing students' minds about intelligence, motivation, and emotions*. Teaching demo presented at the 2025 Psychology One Conference, Durham, NC.

Rivero, A. & Tomasello, M. (2025, May). *The emergence of children's group cooperation*. Poster presented at the 2025 Society of Research in Cognitive Development (SRCD), Minneapolis, MN.

Brouwers, J., **Rivero, A.**, Wynn, S. (2025, February). *Improving students' group project experiences*. Presentation for the 2025 Annual Critical Questions in Education Conference, Savannah, GA.

Brouwers, J., **Rivero, A.**, Vieth, A., & Hard, B. M. (2024, August). *How to ACE group projects: Addressing the barriers to collaborative learning*. Poster presented at the 2024 Annual Convention for the American Psychological Association (APA), Seattle, WA.

Rivero, A., Brouwers, J., Vieth, A., & Hard, B. M. (2024, May). *How to ACE group projects: Addressing the barriers to collaborative learning*. Poster presented at the 2024 Annual Convention for the Association of Psychological Science (APS), San Francisco, CA.

Rivero, A., Brouwers, J., Wynn, S., & Hard, B. M. (2024, March). *How to ACE group projects: Addressing the barriers to collaborative learning*. Presentation for the 2024 Annual Critical Questions in Education Conference, New Orleans, LA.

Brouwers, J., **Rivero, A.,** Vieth, A., & Hard, B. M. (2023, August). *Why students hate group projects: Understanding and addressing the psychological barriers to collaborative learning*. Poster presented at the 2023 Annual Convention for the Association of Psychological Science (APS), Washington, DC.

Rivero, A., Brouwers, J., Vieth, A., & Hard, B. M. (2023, May). *Why students hate group projects: Understanding and addressing the psychological barriers to collaborative learning*. Poster presented at the 2023 Annual Convention for the American Psychological Association (APA), Washington, DC.

INTERNAL AWARDS & GRANTS

2025	<i>Lafitte Small Grant</i> , Duke Psychology and Neuroscience	\$800
	<i>Undergraduate Research Support Conference Grant</i> , Duke University	\$800
	<i>Undergraduate Research Support Grant</i> , Duke University	\$800
2024	<i>Lafitte Small Grant</i> , Duke Psychology and Neuroscience	\$800
	<i>Lafitte Travel Grant</i> , Duke Psychology and Neuroscience	\$1,600
	<i>Vertical Integration Program</i> , Duke Psychology and Neuroscience	\$4,500
	<i>Morris Fellowship</i> , Duke Center for Family and Child Policy	\$1,000
2023	<i>Psychology and Neuroscience Travel Grant</i> , Lafitte Foundation	\$1,600
	<i>Undergraduate Research Support Grant</i> , Duke University	\$800
	<i>Morris Fellowship</i> , Duke Center for Family and Child Policy	\$1,000
2022	<i>Morris Fellowship</i> , Duke Center for Family and Child Policy	\$1,000

TEACHING

Guest Lectures:

Developmental Psychology: “Prosocial Development,” (Spring 2026)

Instructor of record: Meltem Yucel, *Michigan State University*

Developmental Psychology: “Prosociality & Cooperation,” (Spring 2026, forthcoming Fall 2027)

Instructor of record: Dorsa Amir, *Duke University*

Introductory Psychology: “Prosociality,” (Fall 2025, Spring 2026, forthcoming Fall 2026)

Instructors of record: Bridgette Hard and Emma Grisham, *Duke University*

Teaching Assistant:

What Makes Us Human? (Spring 2026)

Instructor of record: Michael Tomasello, *Duke University*

Psychology Research Methods and Statistics II (Spring 2025)

Instructor of record: Angela Vieth, *Duke University*

Introduction to Psychology, Costanzo Teaching Fellowship (Fall 2023, Spring 2024, Fall 2024)

Instructors of record: Bridgette Hard and Emma Grisham, *Duke University*

INVITED TALKS

2026 *Early Childhood Cognition Lab* (PI: Tamar Kushnir), *Duke University*
Thomas Lab (PI: Ashley Thomas), *Harvard University*
Duke Teaming & Insight Committee: “Research into Collaborative Learning”

2025 *Early Childhood Cognition Lab* (PI: Tamar Kushnir), *Duke University*
Duke Community Affairs: “Community-Engaged Scholarship”
Duke Board of Trustees: “Duke’s External Engagement”
Psychology Majors Union, *Duke University*: “Getting Involved in Research”

2022 *Duke Heads of Assessment*: “How to ACE Group Projects”
Duke Education Faculty Meeting: “Helping Students ACE Group Projects”
Duke BASS Connections: “Studying Student Experiences in the Classroom”

ACADEMIC SERVICE & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

2025-Present *Teaming Innovation and Insight Committee*, *Duke University*
2025 *Prospective PhD and RA Event in Psychology (PPREP)*, *Harvard University*
2024 *Vertical Integration Program (VIP)*, *Duke University*
2022-2024 *Consultant at the Thompson Writing Studio*, *Duke University*

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT

2025-Present *Crew Lead, Habitat for Humanity*
2024-2025 *Strategic Impact Intern, Duke Homebuyers Club*, *Duke University*
2024 *Student Engagement Intern, Duke Community Affairs*, *Duke University*
2022-2025 *Founder and President, New Neighbors Project*, *Duke University*

MENTORSHIP

Senior Thesis Students

- Carolina Deus *“Differential goals on children’s explore-exploit tendencies”*
- Camila Acquarone *“Signals of agency: Human-AI cooperation”*
- Alison Pfaff *“Collaborative excellence award on cooperative learning”*

Summer Intern Program Research Assistants

- Hannah Brown ● Brianna Silva

Undergraduate Research Assistants

- Claire Heyne ● Norah Rosanbalm ● Jeanie Jia
- Naomi Holtzman ● Dalys Ragland ● Beatriz Lopez
- Kathleen Nguyen ● Alison Pfaff ● Carolina Deus
- Nala Reid ● Alana Weisberg ● Lola Lopez-Spencer
- Camila Acquarone ● Hannah Brown ● Taylor Donovan
- Taylor Dannis ● Riley MacDermott

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

- Society for Research in Child Development
- Child Development Society
- Association for Psychological Science
- American Psychological Association